deployed across Kashmir. What aggravates the situation is the rampant illegal mining of riverbed materials, a newly booming nocturnal industry in Kashmir. The unabated mining of sand, gravel and rocks in these mineral-rich water bodies has altered the ecological balance—increasing vulnerability to floods—and also miscued irrigation schemes with specific alignment properties to the waters. "The situation is alarming, our men are working day and night," says a senior irrigation official. A series of emergency measures are afoot: drought pumps, desiltation works, temporary canal storages et al.

Kashmir has a total of 132,000 hectares under paddy cultivation. The irrigation department estimates 15,000 ha. of this is dry presently. This is on top of an existing, structural deficiency. Rice is staple food in Kashmir. But its 5 lakh-plus metric tonnes of local harvest need to be supplemented with another 3 lakh metric tonnes of imports from the Food Corporation of India.

The area under paddy is already fading to urbanisation and diversion to cash crops like apples. The water crisis adds to the pain. Global climate change is hard local reality here, with untold strains on the Himalayan glacier bank. What the drought of 2025 presages is a long-term threat to food security.

"There's a need to look for long-term solutions," says the official. He calls for wise climate adaptation strategies to be mixed in with emergency contingency measures: a shift to less water-intensive crops, but also immediate construction of dams, water harvesting tanks et al. All this recalls another drought: that of funds. "Central funds have dried up over the past four years, and there remains a liability of over Rs 50 crore." Some drizzles there can be a start to healing. ■

▶ GUJARAT

SURAT GEM POLISHERS LOSE THEIR SHINE

An exodus of jobless workers, a spate of suicides put a dark gloam on Surat's crisis-hit diamond industry

By **Jumana Shah**

JOBLESSNESS as an occupational hazard? Yes, and it can be fatal, pretty frequently it seems, for those who work the machines in Surat's diamond industry these days. Last July, Sagar Makwana (21), a polisher, died by suicide after losing his job. Come September, thirtysomething Nikunj Tank went the same way, after a spell of deep depression. He left behind two children and a wife. May this year saw the death of Kapil Nimavat, 45, another jobless diamond worker with two schoolgoing children. The Diamond Workers' Union of Gujarat (DWUG) cites over 100 deaths in the past three years—55 suicides in the past year alone.

How did we get here? It's a full-blown crisis in the diamond industry. Natural diamond sales saw a severe slump after 2022. Lab Grown Diamonds (LGDs)—70 per cent cheaper—got more popular. Now the global markets are sitting on an unprecedented glut of natural diamonds following a 25-30 per cent wholesale price correction. Over the past three years, manufacturers have had to significantly reduce their output.

In times of such economic distress, the pain primarily flows downward: in this case, the 800,000 diamond artisans of Surat, often migrants from Saurashtra and elsewhere, who form a bulk of the nearly



LESS SPARKLE A worker at a factory making lab-grown diamonds near Surat

AFP